

YUGEN

August 22nd, 23rd

CONTINUOUS CRISIS COMMITTEE BACKGROUND GUIDE

Agenda: The Suez Crisis

Freeze date: November 1st 1956

Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

It is our distinct pleasure to welcome you to the Continuous Crisis Committee at Yugen Porps, with the committee stood on 1 November 1956. The Suez Crisis presents a particularly compelling setting for a continuous crisis committee. It is a situation in which diplomacy, military calculations, domestic political pressures, international law, intelligence, economic interests, and great-power rivalry converge within an extraordinarily compressed timeframe. As the Executive Board, we expect this committee to reflect precisely that uncertainty.

We would also like to clarify the purpose of the Background Guide provided to you.

The guide is intended to establish a common foundation for the committee. It introduces the historical context, principal actors, relevant developments, and broad strategic considerations necessary to understand the crisis. It should therefore be treated as a starting point for research, rather than a substitute for research itself. Delegates are strongly encouraged to investigate the crisis independently and develop an understanding that extends well beyond the material contained within the guide. The guide is deliberately not exhaustive. It cannot, and is not intended to, anticipate every political calculation, military consideration, diplomatic position, intelligence development, or historical interpretation that may become relevant during the committee. Furthermore, the Background Guide shall not be considered an evidentiary source and may not be cited as evidence during committee. Information contained within the guide should instead direct delegates towards the subjects and questions upon which further research should be conducted.

We look forward to seeing you navigate one of the most consequential international crises of the twentieth century.

Best of luck, and we look forward to welcoming you to committee.

The Executive Board
Moderator- Ayaan Khan

Deputy Moderator- Adhrit

1. ORIENTATION

1. The dispute in outline

The Suez Canal is a man-made waterway cutting through Egyptian territory, joining the Mediterranean Sea to the Red Sea. It is the shortest sea route between Europe and Asia, and by 1956 the largest single item passing through it is petroleum bound for Western Europe.

Although the Canal lies entirely inside Egypt, it was not operated by Egypt. From its opening in 1869 until July 1956 it was run by a private company, the Suez Canal Company, whose board sat in Paris and whose largest single shareholder was the British Government. Egypt had sold its own shares in 1875 to pay off debts. Under a 1949 arrangement Egypt received about seven per cent of the company's gross profits, roughly two million Egyptian pounds a year out of company profits of around thirty-one million.

On 26 July 1956 the President of Egypt, Gamal Abdel Nasser, nationalised that company. Egypt took over its assets and its operations, promised to compensate the shareholders at the market price of their shares, and stated that the Canal would remain open to all shipping as before. The stated purpose was to use the Canal's revenues to build the Aswan High Dam, after the United States, the United Kingdom and the World Bank had withdrawn their offer of finance for the dam one week earlier.

The United Kingdom and France objected. Their argument was not primarily that Egypt lacked the power to nationalise a company on its own soil. Their own legal advisers told them Egypt probably did have that power. Their argument was that a waterway on which Western Europe depended for its oil should not be under the sole control of one government, and in particular not under the control of a government they regarded as hostile and unpredictable. Britain had a further concern: Nasser's broadcasts and subsidies were undermining British influence across the Arab world. France had a separate concern: Egypt was supporting the rebellion against French rule in Algeria.

Three months of negotiation followed. Two international conferences were held in London. A mission went to Cairo and was rejected. A users' association was set up and did nothing. The matter went to the United Nations Security Council,

which on 13 October 1956 unanimously agreed six principles that any settlement would have to satisfy, including free passage for all shipping and respect for Egyptian sovereignty. Those two requirements pulled in opposite directions and the machinery to reconcile them was never agreed.

Underneath the negotiations, Britain and France had been preparing military action since the end of July. In late October they reached a secret understanding with Israel, which had its own reasons for wanting a war with Egypt:

Egyptian-sponsored raids across the frontier, Egypt's new Soviet-supplied weapons, and Egypt's closure of the Straits of Tiran to Israeli shipping. Under that understanding, recorded in a document signed at Sevres near Paris on 24 October 1956, Israel would attack Egypt; Britain and France would then demand that both sides withdraw from the Canal and would occupy the Canal Zone themselves, presenting this as an intervention to protect the waterway.

Israel attacked on 29 October. The ultimatum followed on 30 October. Egypt rejected it. British and French bombing began on the evening of 31 October.

The Committee convenes on 1 November 1956, three days into that war.

2. Terms used in this guide

Concession. A grant by a government to a company giving it the right to build and operate something, usually for a fixed number of years, after which the asset returns to the state. The Suez Canal Company held a concession of ninety-nine years from the Canal's opening, due to expire on 17 November 1968.

Nationalisation. The taking of privately owned property into state ownership, normally with compensation. Distinct from confiscation, which is taking without compensation.

Khedive. The title of Egypt's hereditary ruler between 1867 and 1914, when Egypt was formally a province of the Ottoman Empire. Replaced by Sultan in 1914 and by King in 1922.

Corvée. Compulsory unpaid labour levied on the peasantry. Used to dig the Canal until 1863.

Protectorate. An arrangement in which one state controls another's foreign affairs and defence while leaving its internal administration formally intact. Britain declared a protectorate over Egypt in 1914 and ended it in 1922.

Armistice. An agreement to stop fighting. It is not a peace treaty and does not end a state of war in law. Egypt and Israel signed an armistice in 1949 and have never signed a peace treaty. This distinction is the basis of most of Egypt's legal arguments about shipping.

Belligerent rights. The rights a state at war has under the customary law of naval warfare, including stopping and searching ships and refusing passage to enemy vessels and to cargo useful for war. Egypt claims these rights against Israel on the ground that a state of war continues.

Fedayeen. Irregular fighters, in this context Palestinians organised and directed by Egyptian military intelligence from 1955, conducting raids into Israel from Gaza and later from Jordan and Lebanon.

Veto. The five permanent members of the Security Council (Britain, China, France, the Soviet Union and the United States) can block any non-procedural decision by voting against it. Britain and France used this on 30 October 1956.

Uniting for Peace. A procedure created by General Assembly Resolution 377 A (V) of 3 November 1950. When the Security Council is blocked by a veto, the matter can be transferred to the General Assembly, where there is no veto and where recommendations are made by majority vote. It was invoked against Britain and France on 31 October 1956.

Baghdad Pact. A defence arrangement signed in 1955 linking Iraq, Turkey, Britain, Pakistan and Iran. Egypt opposed it. It is the main dividing line in Arab politics in 1956.

Sawt al-Arab. The Voice of the Arabs, an Egyptian radio service broadcasting across the Arab world since 1953. Egypt's principal instrument of regional influence.

3. The Suez Canal: what it is and what it carries

The Canal runs 101 miles, or 163 kilometres, from Port Said on the Mediterranean coast to the town of Suez on the Gulf of Suez. It has no locks,

because the two seas are at effectively the same height. A ship simply steams through.

The channel is not wide enough for two large ships to pass except at widened points and in the lakes along the route, principally Lake Timsah at Ismailia and the Great Bitter Lake. Traffic therefore moves in timed convoys, normally three each day, and the transit takes about fifteen hours. Every vessel takes a pilot, and pilotage, dredging, towage and signalling are provided by the operating authority. The Canal cannot function without them, which becomes significant in September 1956.

Three towns lie along it: Port Said at the northern end, Ismailia at the midpoint, and Suez at the southern end. The area around them is known as the Canal Zone, and it was the site of the British military base until June 1956.

The traffic figures for 1955 were 14,666 transits carrying about 107 million tons. Between two-thirds and three-quarters of that was petroleum moving north from the Persian Gulf to Western Europe. Approximately half of British oil imports came through the Canal. Most of the remainder arrived by pipeline from the Iraqi oilfields at Kirkuk across Syria to the Mediterranean, or by tanker around the Cape of Good Hope, which is a far longer voyage requiring far more shipping. Western European oil stocks in the autumn of 1956 amount to roughly six weeks of consumption.

The Canal is also the main sea route between Britain and its remaining possessions east of Suez, and between Europe and India, Pakistan, Ceylon, Australia and New Zealand.

Everything in the crisis follows from a single geographical fact: the waterway on which Western Europe's fuel supply depends lies inside the territory of a country that had no ownership of it and no control over it.

2. HOW THE SITUATION AROSE, 1854 TO 1952

4. The building of the Canal and the loss of the Egyptian share

The Canal was built under two grants made by Mohammed Said Pasha, Viceroy of Egypt, to Ferdinand de Lesseps, a French diplomat who had served as consul at Alexandria and knew Said personally. The first grant is dated 30 November 1854 and the second, containing the detailed terms, 5 January 1856.

The terms were generous to the company and expensive for Egypt. The company received the land it needed on both banks free of charge, together with the right to dig a freshwater canal from the Nile to supply the works. Egypt undertook to supply four-fifths of the labour. Egypt was to receive fifteen per cent of the net profits, and the whole undertaking would revert to the Egyptian state after ninety-nine years counted from the day the Canal opened.

The company formed in 1858 was the Compagnie Universelle du Canal Maritime de Suez. Its capital was 400,000 shares. European investors did not take up the whole issue, and Said subscribed 176,602 shares, about forty-four per cent, to make up the shortfall. By a convention of 22 February 1866 the company was declared to be Egyptian and subject to Egyptian law, with its registered seat in Egypt and its administrative offices in Paris. That 1866 instrument becomes important in 1956, because it is what allows Egypt to say that the company it nationalised was an Egyptian company.

Digging began in 1859. For the first four years the labour was *corvée*, drafted from the villages of the Delta and Upper Egypt at a rate of about twenty thousand men at a time. No reliable record of deaths was kept. Egyptian accounts put the figure very high; there is no register capable of verification either way.

The *corvée* was abolished in 1863 by Said's successor Ismail, following British diplomatic pressure. The company claimed compensation for losing its guaranteed labour supply, and an arbitration by the Emperor Napoleon III on 6 July 1864 required Egypt to pay the company 84 million francs. Egypt was, in effect, required to pay for no longer being obliged to supply forced labour.

The Canal opened on 17 November 1869. The ninety-nine year term therefore ends on 17 November 1968.

Egypt's financial position then collapsed. Ismail had borrowed heavily on the European market at rates that delivered only a fraction of the nominal loan, and had spent on public works, a war in Ethiopia and the Sudan. On 25 November

1875 he sold Egypt's 176,602 shares to the British Government for four million pounds. Benjamin Disraeli arranged the purchase without waiting for Parliament, borrowing the money from the banking house of Rothschild. Egypt's fifteen per cent share of the profits had already been pledged to creditors and was extinguished by a further sale in 1880.

From 1880, therefore, Egypt held no shares in the company operating the Canal on its territory, received nothing from its profits, and had no voice in its management. Britain held about forty-four per cent of the shares. Most of the rest were held by private investors in France. Only in 1949 did Egypt obtain, by agreement with the company, seven per cent of gross profits and additional seats on the board.

5. The British occupation of 1882

Egypt's default in 1876 brought European supervision of its finances. A Debt Commission was established, an Anglo-French Dual Control took charge of Egyptian revenues in 1878, and European ministers were placed in the Egyptian cabinet. When Ismail resisted, Britain and France arranged his deposition through the Ottoman Sultan in 1879, replacing him with his son Tewfik.

Resistance came from within the Egyptian army. Colonel Ahmed Urabi led a movement against foreign control of Egyptian finances and against the domination of the officer corps by the Turkish and Circassian elite. By 1882 Urabi was Minister of War and effectively directing the government. Riots at Alexandria in June 1882 killed about fifty Europeans.

A British squadron bombarded Alexandria on 11 July 1882. A British expeditionary force landed, used the Canal itself as its line of operations, and destroyed Urabi's army at Tel el-Kebir on 13 September 1882.

Britain declared the occupation temporary and repeated that declaration many times over the following forty years. British forces remained in Egypt continuously from 1882 until 13 June 1956.

The occupation did not change Egypt's formal status. Egypt remained in law an Ottoman province under a hereditary Khedive. In practice the country was administered through the British Agent and Consul-General, an office held from 1883 to 1907 by Lord Cromer, whose advice to Egyptian ministers could not be

refused. In 1899 the Sudan, reconquered by an Anglo-Egyptian force, was placed under joint Anglo-Egyptian administration, which gave Britain control of the upper Nile and gave Egypt a grievance it pursued until 1956.

6. The Convention of 1888: the rulebook for the Canal

The Convention Respecting the Free Navigation of the Suez Maritime Canal was signed at Constantinople on 29 October 1888 by nine powers: Britain, France, Germany, Austria-Hungary, Spain, Italy, the Netherlands, Russia and the Ottoman Empire. Egypt was not a separate signatory, because in 1888 Egypt was an Ottoman province and the Sultan signed for it. Egypt has since accepted that it is bound, and confirmed this in its treaties with Britain in 1936 and 1954.

What the Convention says, in substance:

- The Canal shall always be free and open, in time of war as in time of peace, to every vessel of commerce or of war, without distinction of flag. It shall never be blockaded (Article I).
- No acts of war may be committed in the Canal or within three miles of its ports, even if the territorial sovereign is itself at war (Article IV).
- Belligerents may not land or embark troops or war materials in the Canal (Article V).
- The consular representatives of the signatory powers in Egypt are to supervise the working of the Convention (Article VIII).
- The Egyptian Government shall take the measures necessary to ensure the Convention is carried out (Article IX).
- Nothing in the Convention prevents the Sultan or the Khedive taking measures with their own forces for the defence of Egypt and the maintenance of public order (Article X), provided those measures do not interfere with free use of the Canal (Article XI).
- The obligations of the Convention are not limited by the duration of the company's concession (Article XIV).

Three points about this document govern the whole 1956 argument.

First, the Convention regulates passage. It says nothing whatever about who owns or operates the Canal. There is no provision requiring that it be run by a company, or by any body other than Egypt. Article IX assumes the opposite:

that responsibility for making the Convention work lies with the Egyptian Government.

Second, Article XIV separates the international guarantee of passage from the commercial concession, expressly stating that one does not end when the other does. The two are different things.

Third, the supervisory machinery in Article VIII has never once been convened in sixty-eight years.

One further detail. Britain signed in 1888 subject to a reservation that suspended the Convention's application for as long as the British occupation of Egypt lasted. That reservation was only withdrawn in 1904.

7. Egypt between the wars, 1914 to 1939

When the Ottoman Empire entered the First World War against Britain in November 1914, the fiction of Ottoman sovereignty over Egypt became inconvenient. Britain declared a protectorate on 18 December 1914, deposed the Khedive and installed a compliant successor with the title of Sultan. Egypt became the base for the Palestine and Sinai campaigns, under martial law, with widespread requisitioning of animals, crops and labour.

In March 1919, after Britain arrested and deported the nationalist leader Saad Zaghloul for asking to present Egypt's case at the Paris Peace Conference, a general insurrection broke out. About eight hundred Egyptians were killed. Zaghloul's movement, the Wafd, became the mass nationalist party.

Britain's response was the Unilateral Declaration of 28 February 1922. It ended the protectorate and recognised Egypt as an independent kingdom, while reserving four matters entirely to British discretion: the security of imperial communications, meaning the Canal; the defence of Egypt; the protection of foreign interests and minorities; and the Sudan. Independence with those four reservations left Egypt without control of its own foreign policy, defence or borders, and Egyptian politics for the next thirty years turned on the effort to remove them.

The Anglo-Egyptian Treaty of Alliance of 26 August 1936 was negotiated after Mussolini's invasion of Ethiopia had alarmed Cairo. It ran for twenty years. Britain withdrew its forces from Cairo, Alexandria and the Delta and

concentrated them in the Canal Zone, limited in peacetime to 10,000 troops and 400 air force personnel. The system of legal privileges enjoyed by foreigners in Egypt, known as the Capitulations, was abolished. Britain sponsored Egypt's entry into the League of Nations. Britain retained the right to use Egyptian facilities in wartime, and nothing changed in the Sudan.

Article 8 of the 1936 Treaty is worth noting. It described the Canal as an integral part of Egypt and as a universal means of communication, and justified the stationing of British troops on the ground that Egypt was not yet able to guarantee the security of navigation by its own resources. Egyptians read that clause as an insult; Britain relied on it as a statement of fact.

The twenty-year term of the 1936 Treaty expires in 1956. That deadline drives the negotiations of the early 1950s.

8. The Second World War and its effects inside Egypt

Egypt was formally neutral for most of the war and was in practice the principal British base in the region. Two battles were fought at El Alamein, about a hundred miles from Alexandria, in July and again between 23 October and 4 November 1942. Wartime inflation and requisitioning caused serious hardship.

The event with the greatest political consequence occurred on 4 February 1942. Britain wanted a particular government installed in Cairo. The British Ambassador, Sir Miles Lampson, surrounded the Abdin Palace with armoured vehicles, entered with the commander of British troops in Egypt, and gave King Farouk the choice of appointing Mustafa el-Nahas as Prime Minister or signing an instrument of abdication that Lampson had brought with him. Farouk appointed Nahas.

The incident had two effects. It destroyed the moral standing of the Wafd, which had taken office at the point of British guns. And it convinced a generation of young Egyptian army officers that Egyptian independence was worthless in practice. Gamal Abdel Nasser and Anwar el-Sadat were among them. Fourteen years later, Nasser's refusal to accept any arrangement leaving foreign personnel in charge of the Canal is directly traceable to this episode, which he cited repeatedly.

The Arab League was founded at Cairo in 1945, with Egypt, Iraq, Transjordan, Syria, Lebanon, Saudi Arabia and Yemen as founding members, and with its headquarters in Cairo.

9. The Palestine war of 1948 and the dispute with Israel

Egyptian forces entered Palestine on 15 May 1948, the day after the British Mandate ended and Israel declared independence. The Egyptian army was unprepared and poorly supplied. A public scandal over defective arms supplied to the army became a national controversy and was taken within the officer corps as proof that the government was corrupt. An Egyptian brigade was encircled at Faluja from October 1948 and held out until the fighting stopped. One of the officers inside the pocket was Major Gamal Abdel Nasser.

The General Armistice Agreement between Egypt and Israel was signed at Rhodes on 24 February 1949. It set demarcation lines, established a Mixed Armistice Commission under United Nations chairmanship, and left Egypt administering the Gaza Strip, a narrow coastal area holding over two hundred thousand people, most of them refugees.

Two features of the 1949 agreement matter permanently. Its Article I bound both parties not to undertake, plan or threaten aggressive action against the other. Its Article II stated that the agreement was dictated exclusively by military considerations and prejudiced no political rights or claims.

No peace treaty followed, between Egypt and Israel or between Israel and any other Arab state. Egypt's position from 1949 onwards is that a state of war continues to exist, that the armistice suspended fighting without ending that state of war, and that Egypt therefore retains the rights of a belligerent, including the right to stop enemy shipping. Everything Egypt does about Israeli shipping rests on that position.

The two shipping disputes

There are two of them, in different places, and they are frequently confused.

The Canal. Since 1948 Egypt has refused passage through the Canal to ships flying the Israeli flag, and to ships of any flag carrying cargo to or from Israel. Ships are stopped and searched at Port Said. A contraband list, initially covering

arms, was extended to petroleum, chemicals, vehicles and some foodstuffs. A blacklist of shipping companies trading with Israel is maintained.

Israel and the Western maritime states say this breaks Article I of the 1888 Convention, which promises free passage to every vessel without distinction of flag. Egypt says Article I does not abolish the ordinary rights of a state at war, that Article X preserves measures for Egyptian defence, and that Britain itself closed the Canal to its enemies in both world wars without any signatory objecting.

The Security Council took Israel's side. Resolution 95 of 1 September 1951 found that neither party could reasonably claim to be actively at war after so long, that the restrictions interfered unjustifiably with the freedom of navigation and trade, and called on Egypt to end them. Egypt did not comply. No enforcement followed. In September 1954 Egypt detained the Israeli vessel Bat Galim at Port Said; the crew were released, the ship was not.

The Straits of Tiran. This is a separate waterway with separate law. The Gulf of Aqaba is a hundred-mile inlet of the Red Sea with Egypt, Israel, Jordan and Saudi Arabia on its shores. Israel's only port there, and its only outlet to the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean, is Eilat. The Gulf is entered through the Straits of Tiran, where the navigable channel runs close to the Egyptian shore at Ras Nasrani. Egypt has held batteries at Ras Nasrani and garrisons on the islands of Tiran and Sanafir since 1949 and 1950, requires prior notification of passage, and in practice refuses passage to Israeli shipping. Eilat is therefore effectively closed.

The 1888 Convention has nothing to do with Tiran. That dispute turns on the customary law of the territorial sea and of straits.

Raids and reprisals

The armistice lines produced constant unauthorised crossings, at first by refugees returning to land and property inside Israel, later by armed parties. Israel adopted a policy of military reprisal against the territory from which the crossings came.

The decisive incident was the Israeli operation at Gaza on 28 February 1955, which struck the Egyptian army headquarters there and killed thirty-seven or thirty-eight Egyptian soldiers. The Security Council condemned it in Resolution

106 of 29 March 1955. Its consequences for Egyptian policy were larger than its scale. It demonstrated that the Egyptian army could not protect territory under Egyptian administration, it produced demonstrations in Gaza directed partly at Nasser, and it convinced Nasser both that he needed modern weapons urgently and that he needed a means of striking back.

From mid-1955 Egyptian military intelligence organised Palestinian irregulars, the fedayeen, and directed raids into Israel from Gaza and later from Jordan and Lebanon. Israeli reprisals continued, at Khan Yunis in August 1955, at el-Sabha in November 1955, at Gaza in April 1956, and against Jordanian territory at Qalqilya on 10 October 1956.

10. The collapse of the monarchy, 1951 to 1952

By 1951 the Egyptian government had no result to show from years of negotiation with Britain, and the 1936 Treaty was running towards its expiry. On 8 October 1951 the Nahas government put decrees before Parliament abrogating both the 1936 Treaty and the 1899 Sudan agreement. They were adopted on 15 October.

Britain refused to accept that a treaty could be terminated by one party alone and kept its forces in place. The garrison in the Canal Zone then numbered about eighty thousand men, in the largest military base complex in the world outside the two superpowers.

There followed a guerrilla campaign. Egyptian auxiliary police, Muslim Brotherhood volunteers and students attacked British convoys and installations. Egyptian civilian workers, on whom the base depended, walked out, and Britain imported labour from Cyprus, Malta and Mauritius.

On 25 January 1952 British forces surrounded the auxiliary police barracks at Ismailia and demanded that the police give up their weapons. The Egyptian Minister of the Interior ordered them to resist. About fifty Egyptian policemen were killed.

The next day, 26 January 1952, central Cairo burned. About seven hundred and fifty premises were destroyed, principally hotels, cinemas, department stores and clubs associated with the foreign community. About thirty people were

killed. Troops were not deployed for several hours. Responsibility has never been established.

The King dismissed the government the following day. Four governments held office in the next six months. The parliamentary system had stopped functioning.

3. EGYPT UNDER NASSER, 1952 TO JULY 1956

11. The revolution and the consolidation of power

On the night of 22 to 23 July 1952, officers belonging to a secret organisation called the Free Officers seized army headquarters, the broadcasting station, the telephone exchange and the main road junctions of Cairo. There was almost no fighting. General Mohammed Naguib, a respected senior officer, was placed at the head of the movement as its public figure; real direction lay with the Revolutionary Command Council, of which Lieutenant Colonel Gamal Abdel Nasser was the leading member.

King Farouk abdicated and left Alexandria on 26 July 1952.

What followed over four years turned a military coup into a personal regime.

In September 1952 the Agrarian Reform Law limited landholdings to two hundred feddans and redistributed the surplus, destroying the economic base of the great landowning families who had run Egyptian politics. In January 1953 political parties were dissolved and their funds confiscated. In June 1953 the monarchy was abolished and Egypt became a republic with Naguib as President.

Through 1954 Naguib and the Revolutionary Command Council fought over the country's direction. Naguib wanted a return to parliamentary government and had the support of the Muslim Brotherhood, the communists and much of the public. The Council did not. Nasser became Prime Minister in April 1954.

On 26 October 1954 a member of the Muslim Brotherhood fired at Nasser during a public speech at Manshiya Square in Alexandria and missed. Nasser continued speaking, and the broadcast made him a national figure. The Brotherhood was banned, several thousand members were arrested, and six were executed in December. Naguib was accused of involvement and removed from the presidency on 14 November 1954.

The Sudan became independent on 1 January 1956, ending one of the four reserved points of 1922. A new constitution was promulgated in January 1956 and approved by plebiscite on 23 June 1956, when Nasser was elected President.

By the freeze date, Nasser is thirty-eight and has held effective power for two years. There is no legislature sitting, no permitted opposition and no independent press. Authority is exercised through the former members of the Revolutionary Command Council, the army under General Abdel Hakim Amer, and the intelligence services.

The most important instrument of Egyptian influence beyond Egypt is not military. It is the radio. Sawt al-Arab, the Voice of the Arabs, broadcasting from Cairo since 1953, reaches ordinary listeners in Baghdad, Amman, Damascus, Beirut, Tripoli, Khartoum, the Gulf and Algeria. It costs almost nothing and it has repeatedly forced Arab governments to change course under pressure from their own populations.

12. The British withdrawal agreement of 1954

Both governments had reasons to settle. Britain had discovered that holding a base against the wishes of the surrounding population required eighty thousand men and produced little of military value. The development of the hydrogen bomb had also reduced the value of a large base concentrated in one area. Egypt wanted the troops gone before anything else could be attempted.

The Agreement regarding the Suez Canal Base was signed at Cairo on 19 October 1954. Its terms:

- All British forces to withdraw from Egyptian territory within twenty months, that is by June 1956.

- The base installations to be kept in working order by about four thousand British and Egyptian civilian contractors.
- A term of seven years.
- Britain entitled to reactivate the base if there were an armed attack by an outside power on any Arab League state or on Turkey.
- Both governments reaffirming, in Article 8, the 1888 Convention and freedom of navigation.

Two points about this agreement matter in 1956. The reactivation clause was deliberately drafted to exclude Israel from the phrase "outside power", precisely so that it could not be triggered by an Egypt-Israel war. In November 1956 Britain intervenes in exactly that situation. And Article 8 gives Britain a recent, express Egyptian commitment on free passage to point to.

The agreement was attacked in Britain by about forty government backbenchers calling themselves the Suez Group, who regarded it as a surrender. Anthony Eden, then Foreign Secretary, carried it through, and arrived in the premiership in April 1955 with the reputation among his own party's right wing of being the man who gave away the Canal Zone.

In Egypt the Muslim Brotherhood attacked it for allowing British technicians to remain and the base to be reactivated. The assassination attempt on Nasser came seven days after signature.

The last British troops left on 13 June 1956, seventy-four years after the occupation began. Egypt marked the day as a national holiday. The nationalisation followed six weeks later.

13. Egypt, the Arab states and the Baghdad Pact

British and American policy in the region rested on assembling a defensive grouping of states along the Soviet Union's southern border. The Pact of Mutual Cooperation was signed at Baghdad by Iraq and Turkey on 24 February 1955. Britain acceded in April 1955, Pakistan in September, Iran in November. The United States supported it without joining.

Egypt opposed it, and the reasons were about Arab politics rather than the Soviet Union. Iraq had broken Arab ranks by making a defence arrangement with outside powers. The Arab League's own joint defence treaty of 1950 was

being bypassed. Britain had found a way to keep military facilities in the region under a new legal form, and had used the pact to replace its old treaty with Iraq while keeping the use of Iraqi airfields. And Baghdad, under the Prime Minister Nuri es-Said, was being established as the Arab capital that mattered instead of Cairo.

Egypt answered with its own agreements, concluding mutual defence pacts with Syria on 20 October 1955 and Saudi Arabia on 27 October 1955, and with a sustained broadcasting campaign against Nuri and against the Hashemite monarchies of Iraq and Jordan.

The contest was fought most visibly in Jordan. When Britain sent General Sir Gerald Templer to Amman in December 1955 to bring Jordan into the pact, riots broke out and two governments fell. Jordan did not join. On 1 March 1956 King Hussein dismissed Lieutenant General Sir John Bagot Glubb, the British officer who had commanded the Arab Legion since 1939, along with other British officers. The British Government attributed this to Egyptian influence, and Eden in particular treated it as a personal defeat inflicted by Nasser.

Elections in Jordan on 21 October 1956 produced a nationalist government under Suleiman Nabulsi, committed to ending the Anglo-Jordanian treaty of 1948. On 24 October 1956 Egypt, Syria and Jordan placed their forces under a unified command headed by the Egyptian commander-in-chief, General Amer.

14. Israel, Gaza and the arms race

On 27 September 1955 Egypt announced an agreement to buy armaments from Czechoslovakia. Everyone understood that Czechoslovakia was acting for the Soviet Union.

The quantities reported were far beyond anything previously supplied to a Middle Eastern state: in the order of two to three hundred medium tanks, a hundred MiG-15 jet fighters, about fifty Ilyushin Il-28 jet bombers, self-propelled artillery, destroyers and submarines, paid for largely in Egyptian cotton on deferred terms.

The consequences ran in several directions.

The Tripartite Declaration of 25 May 1950, by which Britain, France and the United States had undertaken to regulate arms supplies to the region and to act

against any state preparing to change the armistice lines by force, ceased in practice to operate.

Israel concluded that Egypt would need about eighteen months to absorb and train on the new equipment, and that Israel's relative position would worsen steadily after that. From late 1955 the Israeli General Staff under the Chief of Staff, Major General Moshe Dayan, planned on that basis. This is why Israel's war planning has a deadline attached to it.

France increased its own supply of weapons to Israel, including Mystere IV aircraft and AMX-13 tanks, through direct contacts between the French defence ministry and Shimon Peres of the Israeli defence ministry.

And Nasser's standing in the Arab world rose sharply, because he had obtained modern weapons without accepting Western conditions.

15. Non-alignment, China and Algeria

Egypt took part in the Asian-African Conference at Bandung from 18 to 24 April 1955, attended by twenty-nine states. Nasser met Nehru, Zhou Enlai, Sukarno and, subsequently, Tito. He returned committed to what he called positive neutralism: refusing association with either bloc while accepting assistance from both.

On 16 May 1956 Egypt recognised the People's Republic of China. In Washington, where the government did not recognise Peking and where a presidential election was approaching, this was taken very badly.

Egypt also supported the National Liberation Front, which had begun an insurrection against French rule in Algeria on 1 November 1954. Egypt provided broadcasting facilities, political support, financial assistance and a base in Cairo for FLN representatives. How much material assistance Egypt actually gave is disputed; the French Government believed it was decisive.

Two incidents in October 1956 hardened French opinion. On 16 October the French navy intercepted the vessel Athos off Morocco carrying Egyptian arms to the FLN. On 22 October French aircraft forced down an aircraft carrying Ahmed Ben Bella and four other FLN leaders and arrested them.

16. The Aswan High Dam and the withdrawal of finance

The High Dam south of Aswan was the central project of the Egyptian government's domestic programme. Egypt's population is about twenty-three million and growing by more than two per cent a year, living on roughly six million feddans of cultivated land confined to the Nile valley and Delta, some three per cent of the country's area. The existing dam at Aswan could not hold back a full year's flood.

The new dam would store several years of flood water, allow year-round irrigation in Upper Egypt, add roughly a third to Egypt's cultivable land, and generate about ten thousand million kilowatt hours of electricity annually for industry. The cost was estimated at around 1,300 million dollars over ten years, of which about 400 million had to be found in foreign currency.

On 16 December 1955 the United States, Britain and the World Bank made a joint offer for the first stage: 56 million dollars from Washington, 14 million from London, and a World Bank loan of 200 million to follow. The Bank attached conditions concerning Egyptian budget discipline, limits on other foreign borrowing, and international tendering. Egypt regarded these as supervision of its economy and negotiations dragged through the first half of 1956.

During the same period Egypt accumulated a series of offences in American eyes: the Czech arms deal, the Bandung conference, the recognition of China, the broadcasting campaign against the Baghdad Pact, the rejection of American mediation efforts between Egypt and Israel, and Egyptian soundings about Soviet financing of the dam.

On 19 July 1956 the Egyptian Ambassador in Washington called on the Secretary of State, John Foster Dulles, to accept the offer. Dulles told him it was withdrawn. The State Department statement said that Egypt's ability to devote adequate resources to the project had become more uncertain than when the offer was made. That is a public statement that Egypt was not creditworthy. Britain withdrew its offer on 20 July, and the World Bank loan, being conditional on the other two, lapsed.

Nasser received the news while returning from a meeting with Tito and Nehru at Brioni in Yugoslavia.

4. THE NATIONALISATION AND THE DIPLOMACY, JULY TO OCTOBER 1956

17. 26 July 1956: what Egypt did

Nasser chose the fourth anniversary of Farouk's departure and spoke at Manshiya Square in Alexandria, the same square where he had been shot at in 1954. He spoke for close to three hours in colloquial Egyptian Arabic rather than the formal classical Arabic normally used for state occasions, recounting the history of the concession, the debt, the sale of Egypt's shares and the labourers who dug the Canal. The speech was broadcast live across the Arab world.

Egyptian personnel under Colonel Mahmoud Younes were waiting to occupy the company's offices and installations at Port Said, Ismailia and Suez. Their signal to move was the name of Ferdinand de Lesseps, which Nasser used in the speech. By the time the crowd had understood what was being announced, the Canal was in Egyptian hands.

The measure was Law No. 285 of 1956. Its substance:

- The Suez Canal Company, described in the law as an Egyptian joint stock company, is nationalised. All its assets, rights and obligations pass to the Egyptian state, and its governing bodies are dissolved.
- Shareholders will be compensated at the closing price of the shares on the Paris Stock Exchange on the day before the law takes effect. Payment will be made after the state has taken complete delivery of all the company's assets.
- Operation of the Canal passes to a new independent body with legal personality, the Suez Canal Authority.
- The company's funds are frozen.
- The company's employees must remain at their posts and may not leave without authorisation, whatever the circumstances, under penalty.

Alongside the law, Egypt declared that it would observe the 1888 Convention, that freedom of navigation would be maintained, and that the revenues of the Canal would fund the High Dam. Nasser gave the figures: the Canal earns around thirty-five million Egyptian pounds a year, of which Egypt receives about two million.

Three things about the measure decide most of the argument that follows.

Egypt nationalised a company, not the waterway. The company was constituted under Egyptian law with its registered seat in Egypt, and the 1866 convention had declared it Egyptian and subject to Egyptian law.

Egypt provided for compensation, in the instrument itself, at market value. The condition attached, that payment follow complete handover, was a lever but not a refusal.

Egypt affirmed the 1888 Convention, and traffic through the Canal continued without interruption from 26 July onwards.

On 27 July Britain blocked Egypt's sterling balances held in London and banned exports of war material to Egypt. France and the United States froze Egyptian assets within their jurisdictions.

18. How the principal states responded

The United Kingdom. Sir Anthony Eden's government treated the nationalisation as a seizure that could not be allowed to stand. Eden's public argument, made in a broadcast on 8 August 1956, was that the pattern was familiar to anyone who had lived through the 1930s and that the Canal could not be left under the unfettered control of one power. A Cabinet committee, the Egypt Committee, was formed on 27 July and military planning began immediately. Reservists were called up on 2 August.

The British Government's own legal advisers, the Lord Chancellor Viscount Kilmuir, the Attorney General Sir Reginald Manningham-Buller and the Foreign Office legal adviser Sir Gerald Fitzmaurice, advised that nationalisation accompanied by compensation was not in itself a breach of international law justifying force. The British case therefore shifted over August and September away from ownership and towards freedom of passage and Egyptian reliability.

Domestically, the opposition under Hugh Gaitskell condemned the nationalisation on 2 August but opposed the use of force without United Nations authority. The Cabinet was not united; the Minister of Defence, Walter Monckton, was doubtful and was moved to another post in October.

France. The government of Guy Mollet, with Christian Pineau as Foreign Minister and Maurice Bourges-Maunoury as Defence Minister, favoured force more strongly than Britain. Its principal concern was Algeria, where about four hundred thousand French troops were engaged, and its belief that the rebellion depended on Egyptian support. France also had the closest relations with Israel of any Western power.

The United States. Eisenhower's position did not change between July and November. He opposed the nationalisation, was willing to apply economic and diplomatic pressure, and was firmly against the use of force. He put this in writing to Eden on 31 July, 2 September and 8 September, arguing that force would drive Arab and Asian opinion towards the Soviet Union and destroy the Western position. Dulles complicated the picture by producing successive schemes that Britain and France read as support and which were not. The presidential election falls on 6 November 1956.

The Soviet Union. Supported Egypt, attended the London Conference in support of the minority proposals, and used its veto in the Security Council on 13 October.

India and the non-aligned states. India accepted Egypt's right to nationalise, opposed international control of the Canal within Egyptian territory, and put forward through V. K. Krishna Menon proposals for a users' body with advisory rather than executive powers. India has a large commercial interest in the Canal, and Indian nationals help operate it.

The Arab states. Syria, Saudi Arabia, Yemen and Jordan supported Egypt. Iraq, tied to Britain through the Baghdad Pact, would not associate itself with measures against Egypt and pressed London against the use of force. Lebanon sought accommodation with both sides. Libya notified Britain that Libyan territory could not be used for operations against Egypt. Sudan, independent since January, opposed intervention. The common factor is that no Arab government, whatever it thought of Nasser privately, could be seen to assist Britain, France or Israel against Egypt.

19. The London conferences and the Menzies mission

First London Conference, 16 to 23 August 1956. Britain, France and the United States invited the eight surviving signatories of the 1888 Convention and sixteen major user states, twenty-four in all. Egypt and Greece declined. Twenty-two attended.

Two sets of proposals emerged. The majority proposals, supported by eighteen states and introduced by Dulles, would have vested operation of the Canal in an international board with Egyptian representation, associated with the United Nations, insulated from the politics of any nation, with tolls fixed by agreement, an equitable return to Egypt, arbitration for disputes, and compensation for shareholders. The minority proposals, supported by India, Indonesia, Ceylon and the Soviet Union, would have left operation with Egypt and created a consultative body of users with advisory and reporting functions.

The Menzies mission, 3 to 9 September 1956. A committee of five states, led by the Australian Prime Minister Robert Menzies, took the eighteen-power proposals to Cairo. Egypt rejected them on the ground that an international board exercising authority over an Egyptian asset inside Egyptian territory was incompatible with Egyptian sovereignty and amounted to a return of foreign supervision under a new name. The talks ended on 9 September. On 5 September, during the mission, Eisenhower stated publicly that the United States was committed to a peaceful solution, which removed whatever pressure the mission carried.

Egypt then proposed a conference of user states to negotiate a new instrument reaffirming free navigation, creating a users' body with consultative functions, and providing for review of tolls. Britain and France did not take it up.

20. The withdrawal of the pilots

On 14 September 1956 the non-Egyptian pilots employed in the Canal left their posts, about two hundred out of a total of roughly two hundred and fifty. The withdrawal was organised by the company with British and French encouragement, on the expectation that Egypt would prove unable to operate the waterway.

Egypt had prepared for it. The Suez Canal Authority under Mahmoud Younes kept the convoys running using the Egyptian pilots who stayed, retired ship masters, naval officers under training, and pilots recruited from Greece, Yugoslavia, India, Poland, the Soviet Union and elsewhere. Convoy frequency was maintained, and the number of transits recorded in September 1956 was at least equal to that of September 1955.

The practical effect was to remove the argument that Egypt was technically incapable of running the Canal, which had been a substantial part of the political case for international operation.

21. The Security Council and Resolution 118

Britain and France referred the question to the Security Council on 23 September 1956, complaining of the unilateral ending of the international system of operation. Egypt filed its own complaint on 24 September concerning Anglo-French threats to Egyptian security.

Public debate ran from 5 to 13 October, alongside private discussions between the Secretary-General Dag Hammarskjöld, the British Foreign Secretary Selwyn Lloyd, the French Foreign Minister Christian Pineau and the Egyptian Foreign Minister Mahmoud Fawzi.

On 13 October the Council adopted Resolution 118. Its first part, six principles for any settlement, passed unanimously by eleven votes to nil:

1. Free and open transit through the Canal without discrimination, overt or covert, covering both political and technical aspects.
2. Respect for the sovereignty of Egypt.
3. Insulation of the operation of the Canal from the politics of any country.
4. Tolls and charges to be fixed by agreement between Egypt and the users.
5. A fair proportion of the dues to be allotted to development of the Canal.
6. Unresolved disputes between the Suez Canal Company and the Egyptian Government to be settled by arbitration, with suitable provision for payment of sums found due.

The second part of the draft, which would have required Egypt to co-operate in giving effect to the eighteen-power proposals, received nine votes in favour with

the Soviet Union and Yugoslavia against. The Soviet vote, being that of a permanent member, prevented its adoption.

Resolution 118 is the most important document on the agenda after the 1888 Convention. Britain, France, Egypt and the Soviet Union all voted for those six principles. Principles 1 and 3 contain what Britain and France wanted; principle 2 contains what Egypt wanted. No machinery reconciling them was ever agreed, and correspondence between Hammarskjold and Fawzi on that question was still continuing in late October.

22. Military preparation and the Protocol of Sevres

Joint Anglo-French military planning began in the last days of July 1956, under General Sir Charles Keightley with Vice-Admiral Pierre Barjot of France as his deputy.

The first plan, Operation Musketeer, provided for a landing at Alexandria and an advance on Cairo, which reflected the fact that the real objective was the Egyptian government rather than the waterway. It was replaced in September by Musketeer Revised: a preliminary air campaign against the Egyptian air force and Egyptian communications, estimated to take up to ten days, followed by an airborne and seaborne assault at Port Said and an advance south along the Canal.

The revised plan carried a structural problem. Cyprus has no harbour able to take an assault convoy, so the seaborne force had to be mounted from Malta, about six days' steaming from Port Said. There would therefore be a long and highly visible gap between the first bombs and the first troops ashore.

Meanwhile France opened a separate channel to Israel. Israel had its own war aims: ending the fedayeen raids from Gaza, opening the Straits of Tiran, and fighting Egypt before the Soviet-supplied equipment was fully absorbed. What Israel would not do was start a war alone and be labelled the aggressor.

A conference was held at Sevres, near Paris, from 22 to 24 October 1956. France was represented by Mollet, Pineau and Bourges-Maunoury; Israel by David Ben-Gurion, Moshe Dayan and Shimon Peres; Britain by Selwyn Lloyd on the first day and afterwards by Patrick Dean of the Foreign Office.

The Protocol of Sevres, dated 24 October 1956, set out the sequence:

- Israel would attack on the evening of 29 October with the aim of reaching the Canal Zone the following day.
- On 30 October Britain and France would address separate demands to Egypt and Israel to stop fighting and withdraw ten miles from the Canal, and would additionally require Egypt to accept Anglo-French occupation of key positions on the Canal.
- If Egypt had not agreed within twelve hours, Anglo-French forces would attack Egyptian targets in the early hours of 31 October.
- Israel would occupy the western shore of the Gulf of Aqaba and the islands of Tiran and Sanafir.
- Israel would not attack Jordan, and if Jordan attacked Israel, Britain would not assist Jordan.
- The arrangements would remain secret.

The existence of the Protocol has not been made public. Britain and France have stated publicly that they had no advance knowledge of Israeli intentions.

5. THE WAR SO FAR, 29 OCTOBER TO 1 NOVEMBER 1956

29 October

Israel had mobilised during the preceding week while allowing the impression to stand that the target was Jordan, where tension was high after the Israeli reprisal raid at Qalqilya on 10 October.

At about 1700 hours, sixteen transport aircraft dropped a battalion of the 202nd Parachute Brigade, about 395 men under Lieutenant Colonel Rafael Eitan, at the Parker Memorial near the eastern entrance of the Mitla Pass, roughly forty-five kilometres from the Suez Canal. The position was chosen to be close enough to the Canal to justify the ultimatum that had already been drafted at Sevres. The rest of the brigade, under Colonel Ariel Sharon, crossed the frontier and drove overland through Kuntilla and Themed to join them.

Other Israeli columns moved on Kusseima and towards the fortified Egyptian positions at Abu Ageila and Umm Katef, held by elements of the Egyptian 3rd Infantry Division. These positions control the road into central Sinai.

Egypt had about two divisions in Sinai. The bulk of the Egyptian army was west of the Canal.

30 October

Britain and France delivered their demands to Cairo and Tel Aviv in the terms agreed at Sevres, allowing twelve hours for a reply. Both governments were to stop fighting and withdraw ten miles from the Canal. Egypt was additionally to accept Anglo-French occupation of Port Said, Ismailia and Suez.

Israel accepted. Its nearest troops were forty-five kilometres from the Canal and it was being asked to withdraw from territory it had not yet reached.

Egypt rejected the demand, on the grounds that it required Egyptian forces to withdraw from Egyptian territory, that it required Egypt to admit foreign troops to Egyptian cities, and that it was addressed in identical terms to the state attacked and the state attacking.

In the Security Council the United States introduced a resolution calling on Israel to withdraw behind the armistice lines and on all members to refrain from force. It received seven votes in favour, with Britain and France voting against and Australia and Belgium abstaining. The British and French votes, being those of permanent members, blocked it. A Soviet draft in similar terms was blocked in the same way.

31 October

Israeli forces attacked Abu Ageila and Umm Katef and met organised resistance. A force sent from the Mitla position into the Heitan Defile was engaged by Egyptian troops in prepared positions and lost about thirty-eight men killed.

At sea, the Egyptian destroyer Ibrahim el-Awal bombarded Haifa early in the morning and was subsequently disabled and captured by Israeli and French warships.

At about 1900 hours local time British and French aircraft, flying from Cyprus and Malta and from the carriers of the Anglo-French fleet, began the air offensive. The targets were the Egyptian airfields: Almaza, Cairo West, Inchas, Abu Sueir, Kabrit, Fayid and Kasfareet. The Egyptian air force, whose Soviet-supplied MiG fighters and Ilyushin bombers were the most modern equipment Egypt possessed, lost heavily on the ground. Surviving aircraft were flown out to Syria and Saudi Arabia.

Egypt began obstructing the Canal by sinking vessels in the channel.

In New York, with the Council blocked by vetoes, Resolution 119 was adopted by seven votes to two, Britain and France against. Because the decision was procedural, the veto did not apply to it. The resolution transferred the matter to an emergency special session of the General Assembly under the Uniting for Peace procedure, which the Western powers themselves had created in 1950 to bypass Soviet vetoes over Korea.

1 November: the freeze date

Nasser ordered the Egyptian army to withdraw from Sinai to positions west of the Canal. The reasoning was that an army in open desert without air cover, facing three air forces, would be destroyed for nothing, and that the decisive ground was the Canal cities and the Delta. The order concedes Sinai to Israel.

Anglo-French air operations continue, now extending beyond airfields to radar installations, communications and transmitting stations.

The Anglo-French assault convoy is at sea, having sailed from Malta. Because of the six-day steaming time it had to sail before anyone could know whether the ultimatum would be accepted.

Egypt is severing diplomatic relations with Britain and France, sequestrating British and French banks, insurance companies and commercial firms, and taking measures against British and French nationals. Weapons are being issued to National Guard and popular resistance units in Port Said, Ismailia, Suez, Cairo and Alexandria.

The Canal is obstructed and closed to traffic.

The First Emergency Special Session of the General Assembly convenes at New York. There is no veto in the General Assembly.

In Hungary, the government of Imre Nagy has declared Hungarian neutrality, announced withdrawal from the Warsaw Treaty and appealed to the United Nations. Soviet forces are moving within Hungarian territory.

6. THE SITUATION ON THE FREEZE DATE

Military position

Egypt has lost most of its air force and is giving up Sinai, but its ground forces west of the Canal are substantially intact and its government is in place. Israel holds most of central and eastern Sinai and is advancing towards the coast and towards the Gulf of Aqaba. Britain and France have air superiority but no troops ashore; their ground forces are at Cyprus, at Malta or at sea.

The Canal

Closed, blocked by ships sunk on Egyptian orders. Clearing it will require a long salvage operation and, as a practical matter, the co-operation of the government whose ships are on the bottom. Egypt therefore controls the timing of its opponents' recovery even while losing the ground war.

Oil

The closure removes the route carrying about half of Western Europe's petroleum imports. The alternatives are the Iraq Petroleum Company pipelines from Kirkuk across Syria to Tripoli and Baniyas, which are intact and running, and the Cape route, which needs far more tankers and far more time. Western European stocks stand at roughly six weeks.

Money

British sterling reserves are under pressure. Support from the International Monetary Fund would require American agreement.

The United Nations

The Security Council is blocked by the votes of two permanent members. The General Assembly is now seized of the matter under Uniting for Peace, where no veto applies and where the Afro-Asian group, the Soviet bloc, the Latin American states and the United States are broadly aligned against the Anglo-French action.

The Arab states

The unified command agreed between Egypt, Syria and Jordan on 24 October has never been tested. Jordan is bound to Britain by the treaty of 1948 and to Egypt by the unified command, has a nationalist government elected ten days ago, and has a large Palestinian population. Iraq is in the Baghdad Pact with Britain and its government is in an untenable public position. Syria holds the pipelines carrying Iraqi oil to the Mediterranean. Saudi Arabia exports oil to Western Europe and has an unresolved dispute with Britain over the Buraimi oasis. Lebanon is exposed commercially and divided internally. Every one of these governments is under pressure from a population strongly opposed to the Anglo-French action.

Elsewhere

Hungary occupies Soviet attention and is before the United Nations at the same time as Egypt. The American presidential election falls on 6 November.

What is a Model United Nations (MUN)?

Model United Nations, or MUN, is a simulation of the United Nations where Delegates take on the roles of diplomats representing different countries. Each delegate researches their nation's policies, debates global issues, and works with others to draft and pass resolutions, just like in the real UN. Committees are based on actual UN bodies, such as the Security Council or Human Rights Council, and follow adapted versions of their procedures. Most popularly the UNA/USA ROP.

Goal of an MUN

The main goal of an MUN is to help participants understand how international diplomacy actually works, through discussion, compromise, and negotiation rather than conflict. Delegates learn to think from a country's perspective, defend national interests, and find solutions that balance realism with cooperation. Beyond policy-making, it builds public speaking, critical thinking, and teamwork skills while encouraging awareness of world affairs. We wish for Delegates to be able to incorporate these skills into their learning experience from the conference.

Rules of Procedure (RoP)

The **UNA/USA Rules of Procedure (RoP)** are the most widely used and recognized format in Model United Nations conferences worldwide. They are designed to ensure that debate proceeds in an organized, diplomatic, and efficient manner, closely reflecting the operations of the actual United Nations. The elements within the UNA/USA RoP that help the committee function effectively are as follows:

- **Motions:** These are formal requests made by delegates to direct the flow of debate such as moving into a moderated or unmoderated caucus, setting or closing the agenda, or entering voting procedure. Motions determine the pace and structure of the session and must be approved by the dais or through a procedural vote.
- **Points:** Points allow delegates to address procedural issues or seek clarification during debate. Common examples include Points of Order (to correct procedural errors), Points of Personal Privilege (for issues of

audibility or comfort), and Points of Inquiry (to ask questions about procedure).

- **Formal Debate:** Conducted through the Speakers' List, this is where delegates make prepared speeches outlining their country's stance and proposed solutions. It forms the backbone of discussion and ensures equal speaking opportunity.
- **Moderated Caucus:** A semi-formal phase where the dais recognizes speakers for shorter, focused interventions on specific subtopics, allowing faster-paced and interactive discussion.
- **Unmoderated Caucus:** An informal, negotiation-based phase where delegates can move freely, form blocs, and collaborate on working papers or draft resolutions.

Here is a link that would help delegates understand the UNA/USA Rules of Procedure better:

[\[http://www.gecmun.com/uploads/2/3/7/0/23702810/%5bgecmun_x%5d_rules_of_procedure_-_una-usa.pdf\]](http://www.gecmun.com/uploads/2/3/7/0/23702810/%5bgecmun_x%5d_rules_of_procedure_-_una-usa.pdf).

The EB would also like to put to notice to the delegates that since our simulation would be of a Joint Crisis Committee, There would be no formal Documentation at the end of the Committee as there is in a Standard UN Committee, There would not be Draft resolutions. Subjective to Committee flow, Upon the discretion of the EB, the committee may end in a press release.

Along with the UNA/USA RoP, this committee will also follow **Crisis Rules of Procedure**, which are explained later in this Background Guide.

What are Directives?

The **Executive Board (EB)** sets the stage for this committee as a **meeting of Foreign Ministers**. Delegates, acting as their respective nations' foreign ministers, engage in discussions and negotiations reflecting their country's foreign policy priorities. Based on these deliberations, ministers may send **recommendations and instructions**, known as **Directives**, to their **Heads of State, national governments, or relevant agencies**. These directives

communicate the delegate's proposed course of action in response to developments within the committee and the evolving situation on the agenda.

A **Directive** is a formal written communication drafted by a delegate that outlines a specific action, decision, or recommendation their government should undertake. It is the central mechanism through which delegates attempt to influence events within the simulation. Directives may address diplomatic, economic, military, or humanitarian measures, and their effectiveness depends on clarity, relevance, and strategic value.

A **Joint Directive** is a directive written and submitted by two or more delegates acting together, typically representing aligned states or partners. For a joint directive to be considered valid, it must carry the **signatures of all participating delegates** involved in its creation and endorsement.

Directives may also be categorized as **Covert** or **Overt**:

- **Covert Directives** represent secret communications or actions known only to the delegate(s) and the Executive Board. These are not announced publicly in committee but may result in updates or developments revealed later through the crisis arc.
- **Overt Directives** are public communications or official diplomatic messages that are openly recognized by the committee and can influence inter-state perception, alliances, or negotiation dynamics.

Once submitted, directives are reviewed and processed by the Executive Board, and their outcomes are classified into the following categories:

1. **Passed with Outcome:** The directive is approved, and its effects are visible to the committee or the wider world through an update or change in the simulation.
2. **Passed without Outcome:** The directive is approved, but its implementation or results remain undisclosed to the committee, with no visible updates provided.

3. **Failed:** The directive is rejected, meaning it has no impact or resulting change within the simulation.

A Directive Shall only be entertained when it is in the following Format:

Directive Name/Number-

From-

To-

Covert/Overt

Joint/Solo

Primary Objective:

Secondary Objective(not compulsory):

Mission Brief:

Plan of Action:

Additional Information:

Signatories to the Directives:

What is a Freeze Date?

A **freeze date** is the specific calendar date (and sometimes time) where the simulation of the committee begins. All historical events up to this exact moment have occurred as they did in reality. From this point forward, history is in the hands of the delegates.

For your committee, the freeze date is **28 July 1948**. This means you should know everything that happened in the world up to this date, but nothing after it.

Hierarchy of Evidence

1. Crisis Updates issued by the Executive Board
2. Outcomes of Passed Directives
3. Official Communiqués
4. Primary Source Documents (Pre-Freeze Date)

5. Contemporary News Agency Reports

6. Delegate Speeches and In-Committee Statements

